EFS WORKS ONLY WITH LINUX At this time, EFS isn't supported by Windows EC2 instances. The Amazon FSx for Windows File Server is an alternative to EFS for Windows workloads. See http://mng.bz/zmq1 to learn more.

Let's take a closer look at how EFS works compared to Elastic Block Store (EBS) and the instance store, introduced in chapter 8. An EBS volume is tied to a data center and can be attached to only a single EC2 instance from the same data center. Typically, EBS volumes are used as the root volumes that contain the operating system, or, for relational database systems, to store the state. An instance store consists of a hard drive directly attached to the hardware the virtual machine is running on. An instance store can be regarded as ephemeral storage and is, therefore, used only for temporary data, caching, or for systems with embedded data replication, like many NoSQL databases, for example. In contrast, the EFS filesystem supports reads and writes by multiple EC2 instances from different data centers in parallel. In addition, the data on the EFS filesystem is replicated among multiple data centers and remains available even if a whole data center suffers an outage, which isn't true for EBS and instance stores. Figure 9.1 shows the differences: EBS is a virtual disk, instance store is a local disk, and EFS is a shared folder.